fishing trawlers over two days. "They will be penalised according to procedures," Manish Meena, the Wildlife Warden of Chennai, tells INDIA TODAY. "Now that the culprits have been caught, the issue should be resolved," he adds. But turtle carcasses continue to show up. Though fishermen have been given Turtle Excluder Devices (TED) that ensure the creatures can escape when entangled in nets, they hardly utilise them as doing so results in lower yields.

Faced with the outrage of activists, the state government formed a task force on January 22 comprising the four agencies with fishermen's associations and local NGOs to protect the turtles. The fishermen claim it is not wholly their fault. "We revere turtles and are equally concerned," says M. Vijesh, president of the Chennai Fishermen's Association. "Another reason for the deaths is pollution in the sea by plastics and industries," Vijesh claims. Using specific coloured lights to keep turtles at bay were among measures discussed in the first task force meeting on January 27.

"During the current nesting season, we have agreed to pull back nets after keeping them for less than an hour in the waters in order to save the turtles," says K. Vinod, another fishing body leader. South Indian Fishermen Welfare Association president K. Bharathi urges the government to take a firm stand against the practice of bottom trawling, which involves dragging large nets along the ocean floor. Additionally, Dharini says, all mechanised boats should mandatorily turn on their vessel monitoring systems (VMS) and suggests regular inspections at fish landing areas.

Taking stock of the alarming situation, the Chennai-based southern regional bench of the National Green Tribunal has threatened to impose a ban on fishing during the turtle nesting season if regulations are flouted. The body count surely warrants some action on mission mode. ■

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